anything below 20 per cent is considered critical. With the demand for power 17 per cent higher this April compared to the same month in the previous year, they stepped up production to meet the demand, eating into their coal inventory. Nearly 86 of the 150 power plants that utilise only domestic coal are thus left with critically low levels of coal stock. The total inventory of coal at thermal power plants across India was 21.55 MT on April 27 against the 66 MT that is usually stocked around this time every year.

In April, the power sector came under additional stress also because of a 50 GW shortfall in capacity. Of the 17.25 GW supplied by gencos relying on imported coal blends, 4.5 GW worth of capacity fell idle because of the skyrocketing fuel prices in the international market. Australian thermal coal traded at $326.35 a tonne this month, compared to $93.5 a year ago. An additional 8 MW capacity was either under repair or going through system upgradation, and therefore, idle. Meanwhile, with reservoirs in hydro-based units yet to fill up because of the summer, they could function at only 25 per cent of their capacity.



"Since there is no monitoring agency for the Revenue Deficit Grant, there's no check on fulfilment of the commitments"

N.K. SINGH
Head, 15th Finance Commission

COAL BLACK HOLE

In another irony, coal production in India is going up but our power plants do not have enough. Coal India's production, for example, went up by 4.43 per cent from 596 MT in 2020-21 to 622 MT in 2021-22. India had also brought in the commercial mining law in 2020 allowing private players to invest,

MOUNTING DUES

India's discoms are saddled with a mountain of dues, a sizeable portion of which is owed by the government. Differential power pricing makes implementation of reforms a challenge

COST OF POWER

Average energy rates in India are as competitive as in the world's two largest economies



CHINA ₹4.50* per kWh

USA ₹5.21* per kWh

INDIA ₹4.50 per kWh

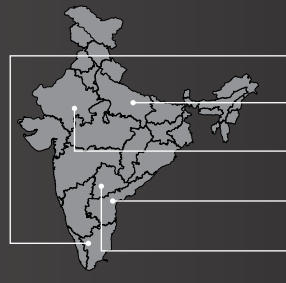
WHO PAYS WHAT

The cost of power varies across categories for the Indian consumer

COMMERCIAL ₹10-12 per unit

RESIDENTIAL ₹2-8 per unit

FARMERS ₹0-3 per unit



	DISCOM DUES (In ₹ cr)	ACCUMULATED LOSSES (In ₹ cr)	SUBSIDY DUES (In ₹ cr)	GOVT DEPT DUES (In ₹ cr)
Tamil Nadu	22,412	19,684	-	2,702
Uttar Pradesh	11,825	5,089	20,940	10,347
Rajasthan	12,163	12,277	17,459	1,832
Andhra Pradesh	10,229	813	13,880	8,307
Telangana	8,239	6,966	-	14,442

*Price is normalised from US$ at a conversion rate of Rs 75 a dollar

Source: Power Ministry; AIPEF